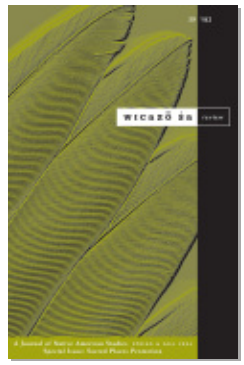
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Deloria's Invocation: The Fourth Kind of Sacred Lands

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Wicazo Sa Review, Volume 39, Numbers 1&2, Spring & Fall 2024, pp. 122-138 (Article)

Published by University of Minnesota Press
DOI: *https://doi.org/10.1353/wic.2024.a966668*

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Deloria's Invocation

The Fourth Kind of Sacred Lands

Daniel R. Wildcat

> Because there are higher spiritual powers who are in communication with human beings, there has to be a fourth category of sacred lands. *Human beings must always be ready to receive new revelations and at new locations.*
>
> —*Vine Deloria Jr., "Sacred Lands and Religious Freedom" (emphasis added)*

Many sacred land issues face Indigenous Peoples today, but two issues, one raised explicitly and another implicitly, in Deloria's fourth category of sacred lands are seldom discussed publicly. The first issue seems worthy of public examination: Are human beings, in this age of the Anthropocene, "ready to receive new revelations and at new locations"?[1] Deloria's prodigious scholarship makes clear that, for American Indians, he believed revelations were tied to sacred places. Place, the land, including all the life residing there, was for Deloria the web of relations through which sacred powers moved and, in exceptional cases, directly revealed themselves with special messages for a People.

Supposing the reception of a new revelation such as Deloria describes, the implicit question of whether our peoples or nations are prepared to deal with new revelations through customary protocols or traditions is worthy of consideration. In the world we now live in, not

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the one our ancestors used to live in, how would revelations be shared and with whom? Are tribal nations prepared to take actions to enact, realize, or fulfill a new revelation? Also, what of the land itself? What actions would be required to protect a new sacred place made manifest with the reception of a revelation?

Obviously, as Deloria realized in the last book he completed before his death, *The World We Used to Live In*, human activity has significantly changed the world we live in compared to the world our ancestors experienced even one hundred or two hundred years ago. Therefore, how we deal with what Deloria numbered the fourth kind of sacred lands, those new places where new revelations are received, must be considered. Consider what follows as an invocation, a rumination, a meditation, and an invitation offered with humility, suggesting we ask ourselves an important question: Are we, the First Peoples of this land, "ready to receive new revelations and at new locations"?

A LITTLE CONTEXT

Vine Deloria Jr. argued that any rational analysis of the sacredness of lands in Western thought must be understood as a matter of convenience: a necessary accommodation to allow discussion with those trained to think in that tradition but not a representation of "the nature of reality." Such a rational discussion at best informs the "principle of respect for the sacred."[2] How could such a discussion do otherwise?

From *God Is Red* (1973) through *The World We Used to Live In* (2006) and, some might argue, his posthumously published work *C. G. Jung and the Sioux Traditions: Dreams, Visions, Nature, and the Primitive* (2009), Deloria argued that Western thinking, indeed the Western worldview, was fundamentally at odds with American Indian worldviews. While this is true, we find interesting convergences between Indigenous knowledges and some recent thinking of Western-trained philosophers and scientists. The divergences in the way we, the First Peoples of this land, and those possessing Western-informed worldviews understand the world in which we live has fundamentally shaped the five-hundred-year-old collision of cultures we have experienced.

It is this five-century-long experience of colonialism—ongoing depredations in an institution-driven hegemonic sense—and our own more recent, two-century-long experience of US policies of enclosure, removal, relocation, and a largely economically driven diasporic movement into the interstices of the US landscape of the American dream that shape this rumination about new revelations in new places. The question I examine here is about our preparation "to receive new revelations . . . at new locations," particularly those revelations beyond the merely personal that have import to an entire people/tribe/nation. All revelations are very personal experiences. The distinction that I

am calling attention to is the difference between revelations that offer instructions with consequences for an individual only versus for an entire people.

This distinction is critical, for while all revelations are a person's (experientially personal) experience, the revelatory religious experiences Deloria examined throughout his work dealt with those that had efficacy for not only the person experiencing the revelation but also a people/tribe/nation. Because Deloria postulates such experiences are fundamentally about sacred places/lands and the convergence of powers that present themselves in a revelatory manner to individuals at places long known to living tribal Peoples, the proposition that we must be prepared to receive revelations at new locations certainly extends Deloria's formulation of sacred lands.

Given our geographic movement to new places, should we expect or be open to receiving revelations at new places? As Peoples within living, not dead, religious traditions—traditions literally grounded in this world—Deloria suggests that we should expect new revelations in new locations. In *God Is Red,* Deloria argued that Western European peoples thought of the nature of the world primarily in a temporal sense, while American Indians thought of the nature of the world from a primarily spatial point of view. As he noted, neither side would understand the other if they failed to consider these conceptual differences, especially when discussing history and religion.[3]

Deloria identified the Eurocentric timeline view of history, which positioned itself as the timeline of world history, as one of the deep obstacles to an appreciation and understanding of American Indian worldviews and thinking traditions, especially Native understanding of and relationship to the land. Deloria postulated, "The fundamental difference is of great philosophical importance. American Indians hold their lands—places—as having the highest possible meaning, and all their statements are made with this reference point in mind."[4] Deloria formulated this fundamental difference as being embodied in a tension between temporal versus spatial metaphysics, which logically carried over into parallel tensions between abstraction versus experience, control versus freedom, and monotheistic anthropocentric religious traditions versus religious traditions literally grounded in oral traditions and revelatory experiences in specific locations.

This article examines three of Deloria's writings that can inform some of the questions, issues, and situations tribal nations might consider in assessing their preparedness—*as nations and communities*—to receive new revelations. Therefore, I do not offer the following as an exhaustive review of Deloria's thoughts on the topic or even of what exists in his voluminous works. Instead, I reflect on key issues that can be distilled from a small sample of Deloria's ideas on this topic. *God Is Red,*

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the *NARF Legal Review* article "Sacred Lands and Religious Freedom," and "Reflection and Revelation: Knowing Land, Places and Ourselves," in Deloria's *For This Land* constitute a good place to start thinking about Deloria's fourth category of sacred lands.

In the 1980s and early 1990s, the work of trying to protect existing sacred lands through legislation required framing the need and right to protection of such places in a way lawmakers could understand. Deloria framed the need to protect sacred sites (lands) by giving legislators something that would make sense to a reasonable person. He suggested four classes or types of sacred places. The first are lands made sacred as a result of events that are important in a people's history. They are typically made and declared sacred by humankind. Ironically, many of these sites are places where large numbers of humans were killed by other humans in warfare. The second and third types of sacred places are the result of sacred powers residing in those places presenting themselves. In the second type, the presence of a power not of our making is felt and made manifest in a place; such places exist across the United States in canyons, riversides, mountainsides, prairies, and so on. The third type of sacred lands "are places of overwhelming holiness where the Higher Powers, on their own initiative, have revealed Themselves to human beings."[5] These are places of revelation where specific knowledge, messages, visions, or challenges are given to the person(s) receiving them. Such places may act as "portals" to a sacred power that chooses to communicate with certain individuals who respectfully seek direct communication.

The first kind of sacred land is the easiest to gain support for special recognition, memorialization, and protection. The other two kinds of sacred lands known to American Indians, Alaska Natives, and Native Hawaiians still lack the legal protection one might expect consistent with the First Amendment of the US Constitution. However, the fourth class of sacred lands raises profound issues about our present relationship with the land and calls for a serious examination of ourselves as Indigenous Peoples.

As we Indigenous Peoples of the United States and its territories think about the protection of sacred lands, we must situate our tribal, Indigenous (that is, People of Places) discussions of sacred lands in the context of our own worldviews. Yes, we have tribal differences, and most of those have to do with the places that we call home—experiences in particular places matter. Deloria contended our tribal metaphysics are founded on the idea that *power* and (plus) *place* equals *personality* (3P).[6] This Indigenous 3P axiom represents our Indigenous cultures as resulting from a symbiotic relationship between a People and a Place. Our deeply relational metaphysics understands power as a nonhierarchical feature of reality permeating the cosmos.

The dominant society's political, economic, religious, educational, and legal institutions bring ideological baggage to our peoples and lands that is not ours to own or carry, and that we must discard and *move off the land* and off our backs. Currently, the interestingly problematic situation is that we have many non-Indigenous people who are tired of carrying this—their own—baggage, too. Before we welcome allies, partners, co-managers, or coalitions, however, the First Peoples of this land must think deeply together about sacred places/lands and our relationship to the sacred power of the land, in order to ensure we are prepared to receive new revelations at new places.

Yes, the Earth is sacred, but we do not treat all land in the same manner. Deloria warned against treating the sacred as a singular monolithic reality: "There is immense particularity in the sacred and it is not a blanket category to be applied indiscriminately."[7] These differences are a function of the particular relationship a people has with a place. Suffice it to say the nature of these relationships can take myriad forms.

The distinction between revelation and reflection is important to understand because Deloria, like many others, believes that reflection regarding the sacred is available to everyone, while revelation is rare primarily because places containing such power are rare. In addition, they represent an event where the "old categories of space and time vanish. New realities take their places and suggest dimensions of life far beyond what we are normally able to discern and understand." And there are places where "some of the medicine men and women describe their feelings as intense dread and foreboding."[8] Given Deloria's emphasis throughout his works on the unique relationship American Indians hold as a result of a prolonged relationship with the land, their homeland, the question is, How can we expect and be prepared "to receive new revelations and at new locations"?

One possible response seems particularly worthy of exploration: few Indigenous Peoples today have been able to maintain the once-vibrant, deep, and expansive relationship they had with the land before they were forced onto reservations. Given our often thousands-of-years-long relationships with places much more expansive than the reservations we were forced onto through acts of removal or enclosure, it seems reasonable that as Indigenous Peoples move over lands once well known to their ancestors—albeit manipulated and rearranged by the settlers so as to be nearly unrecognizable—the land might indeed still recognize us. Deloria's American Indian metaphysics—power and (plus) place equals personality—certainly provides the basis for understanding land acknowledgments as a two-way street.[9] It is perfectly plausible to understand not only land acknowledgments made by humans but acknowledgments of our human relationship to a particular place made by the land. I recommend serious consideration, examination, and openness to the possibility that a land acknowledgment might

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be issued by the land to humankind and might indeed take the form of a revelation.

Before we examine the issue of American Indians today receiving revelations of the nature I have suggested—those containing information beyond a personal nature and with import to a people or nation—I want to raise the question of how our peoples or nations would respond to such an event today. In short, supposing such a revelation were received by a tribal member, are our tribal nations prepared to deal with such a rare and important event?

THE READINESS OF OUR NATIONS

If your people, tribal nation, and those entrusted with the responsibility for consideration and handling of what Deloria called "new revelations and at new locations" are prepared to do so, then you need not read any further—stop here. However, if your tribal nation has not considered how such revelations will be handled, consider the following rumination, or meditation, on some issues that might be considered. Nothing presented here is authoritatively prescriptive, for only arrogance and stupidity would allow one to tell other Peoples how to handle their revelations. Each people/nation holds the authority to determine a proper protocol for revelations received for their tribal people/nation. Consider this one merely Yuchi's (Euchee's) meditation on issues related to the receiving of new revelations on revealed sacred lands: I hope these thoughts are useful to consider in the technosphere-blanketed world we now inhabit.

We, tribal Peoples in the United States of America, expend tremendous effort and dollars trying to protect our sacred lands. The protection and, in many cases, the rematriation (that is, Land Back), of ancient sacred places must be an ongoing task. However, amidst our changing tribal situations and landscapes—physically, socially, culturally, and especially spiritually—it seems appropriate to ask whether our tribal nations, our peoples, are prepared to receive new revelations in new places as part of our living religious traditions. As Vine Deloria Jr. often emphasized, if we restrict sacred sites, places, and lands to those that manifested themselves in ancient times, we seem to concede the point to which many lawyers, courts, scholars, and sadly, some leaders of institutionalized or organized religions seem to blindly or, dare I say, faithfully adhere: Religions are about the past. Deloria succinctly states the prevailing view of those living in a scientism-obsessed and disenchanted world: "Traditional religious practitioners should restrict their identification of sacred locations to those that were historically visited by Indians implying that, at least for federal courts, God is dead."[10] Deloria, throughout his life, argued our religious traditions, while threatened, are not dead.

Our religions are living, and this fact alone is reason to examine our readiness for new revelations. This was the thinking Deloria expressed in the *NARF Legal Review* (1991) a decade after the publication of his least-read and most ambitious intellectual undertaking, *The Metaphysics of Modern Existence (1979)* where he ironically suggests, "Efforts of tribal peoples to retribalize and return to their original posture to the world collapse in the face of an affluent technology that rips them apart." Hardly an endorsement of living tribal religious traditions. Indeed, in *Metaphysics* Deloria states, "We face the future immediately, and while we can be aware of the sound basis for primitive beliefs and customs, we can never return to them or take them up, expecting them to save us."[11] First, Deloria's "we" in this statement refers to everyone in the modern world. Second, while Deloria's appropriation/use of the dominant society's denomination of tribal religions as *primitive* is disconcerting, keep in mind that *Metaphysics,* more than any book he wrote up to that point, was addressed to intellectuals and scientists deeply in engaged in what Deloria calls the metaphysics of modern existence. As he addresses Western theologians, scientists, historians, and intellectuals, Deloria intentionally uses a language that will not confuse them with respect to the substantive point(s) he wants to make: an existential intellectual indictment of Western metaphysics as they are embodied in the institutions of the modern world.

Throughout *Metaphysics* Deloria is wrestling with the metaphysics of the modern world, an overwhelmingly Western-influenced world, so why bring Indigenous or tribal Peoples into this critique when he seems to be saying tribal religious realities in "a modern, electronic age . . . cannot withstand the future shock of a rapidly changing style of life"? The last pages of his discussion of "Tribal Religious Realities" in *Metaphysics* provide the answer. Based on his discussion of *oikumene,* Deloria observes "the most fruitful avenues of development today are directing us [everyone] toward a new type of social existence that parallels primitive peoples', and perhaps incorporates some of their insights or unconsciously adopts some of their techniques, but that will be fully modern and capable of providing a meaningful existence."[12]

In short, while Deloria in the late 1970s seemed doubtful that tribal religious traditions could withstand the eclipse of the natural world by what we know today as the human-created technosphere (more on this later), he was hopeful that "the movements of primitive peoples" would offer those in the institutions of modern society a chance to see and adopt ways of organizing their institutions so that they "reflected a more comprehensive and intelligent view of the world."[13] With the awakening of the modern environmental movement in the seventies and the passage of the Environmental Protection Act (1970), and the American Indian Religious Freedom Act (1978), what initially reads as a rather bleak assessment of tribal religious realities

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actually seems optimistic that fundamental change in religious attitudes and institutions of modern society might come. Deloria saw change coming, as the result not of a single movement, especially not one led by Indigenous Peoples, but of an emerging change influenced by a growing awareness that in 1979 there still remained peoples on the planet who understood their lives—physically, spiritually, and culturally—as inextricably related to the natural world we live in.

Deloria's deep dive into modern Western metaphysics must be reckoned with, for ultimately it shapes all of his later writing on religion, history, sovereignty, rights, self-determination, and self-governance. Even when addressing legal issues, his approach is implicitly comparative: Indigenous thinking compared to Western and/or modern thinking. His work never took the label of decolonization theory because during his lifetime, colonization was often employed in reference to a nation-state's political power. Deloria's more radical undertaking was to situate Western colonialism in its proper place—the mind, consciousness, and often unconscious acceptance of a worldview that ultimately denies community and replaces it with nearly sacrosanct ideas of *individuality*. Western colonialism separates/alienates humans from nature in a rationalized world full of resources as opposed to an Indigenous kin-centric and deeply relational ecological view of our human relationship with the balance of "nature."

NAME THE DIF BETWEEN WESTERN VS. INDIGENOUS

The challenging ideas contained in *Metaphysics* must be addressed when considering sacred lands because, even with a sympathetic reading, Deloria's admiration for the superiority of tribal religious realities over Christian religious realities seems strangely at odds with his bleak assessment of the future of tribal religious traditions. Yet, in 1979 he saw modern institutions moving to embrace what today would be called a more holistic view of the natural world and humankind's place in nature. In the decade between *Metaphysics* and his publication of "Sacred Lands and Religious Freedom," his optimism about emerging societal change waned. Greatly disappointed in the lack of public and academic engagement with his ideas, Deloria appears to have given up hope that the deep thinkers of modern Western metaphysics and, more importantly, the leaders of modern institutions would adopt "a more comprehensive and intelligent view of the world" in line with Indigenous knowledges and wisdom.[14]

Instead of waiting for Western intellectuals and thought leaders to come around, Deloria set about developing and explicitly stating an axiom of American Indian metaphysics—the 3P axiom—essentially a deeply relational notion of the cosmos and our human place in it.[15] Both reflection and revelation are relational experiences. For Deloria, reflection on the beauty of a place and the ensuing sense of wholeness and peace are very much akin to the religious feeling that William James endorsed in *The Varieties of Religious Experience* and which Freud declared in

Civilization and Its Discontents that he had never felt or contemplated. Both reflection and revelation are a result of experience, but the revelatory experience is more dramatic, profound, personal, and consequential to the recipient. However, while the revelatory character of the *discovery* of new sacred lands is a deeply personal experience, the substantive character of an individual's revelation that has importance for a people or nation will necessarily require a process or protocol for enactment of the message or insight received.

The substantive character of a revelatory experience may not be immediately understood by the person receiving it, but if and when such an experience is understood to be transcendent of personal importance, it is necessary to have in place protocols and processes to deal with such an event. Again, I offer the following as merely a starting point for consideration.

ARE WE PREPARED?

Undoubtedly, the kinds of questions that emerge are shaped by the character of revelation itself, as a special class of experience that is impossible to predict. Given our deep spatial connection to the land over millennia and our ceremonial acknowledgment of and engagement with sacred lands, I suggest considering our preparedness as falling under several topics: community or nation(al) health and resilience; establishment of tribal protocols for recognition of revelatory experiences; and questions regarding public, private, and/or covert social engagement. This list is hardly exhaustive, but it does allow us to start asking important questions and facilitating difficult discussions about our preparedness to receive new revelations at new places.

To be clear, preparation, in the sense I use the term here, is not a checklist or check-the-box activity but a self-critical consideration undertaken with humility and respect for our histories, traditions, and cultures and a consideration of our tribal origins, cosmologies and, ultimately, as Deloria would emphasize, metaphysics.

A People's (Tribal) Health and Resilience

In *God Is Red*, Deloria observed:

> Changing the conception of religious reality from a temporal to a spatial framework involves surrendering the place of teaching and preaching as elements of religion. Rearrangement of individual behavioral patterns is incidental to the communal involvement in ceremonies and the continual renewal of community relationships with the holy places of revelation. Ethics flow from the ongoing life

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> of the community and are virtually indistinguishable from the tribal or communal customs. There is little dependence on the concept of progress either on an individual or community basis as a means of evaluating the impact of religious practices. Value judgments involve present community realities and not a reliance on part of future golden ages toward which the community is moving or from which the community has veered.[16]

Communal involvement, community relationships, the ongoing life of the community, and community realities—communities in place—are the environment of religious reality and revelation. Therefore, it is community or tribal health and wellness that we must think deeply about, for resilience, like revelation, is based on the physical, mental, and spiritual health of our tribal community.

The "present community realities" we face represent the challenges many of our nations might face in the handling of a revelation. The fact that many nations have within their midst many different religions across the spectrum of institutionalized Christianity poses real challenges. As ceremonial traditions continue and in some cases are revitalized, the reality of so-called religious differences, often within families, must be taken into account. Even in the best of situations—ecumenical understanding or simply agreeing to amicably disagree—it is incumbent to consider how a revelation of the nature discussed here might be handled. I have no answers, but we must imagine possible reactions among our People and how we might deal with them in a healthy and respectful manner. In precolonial times the shared experiential reality of ceremonies, customs, and habits made the kind of "religious" issues we now face in our nations unimaginable.

In our highly psychologized social realities today, the first impulse some of our people would have on being confronted with a person claiming to have had a very rare vision or revelation for their tribe would be to demand a psychiatric evaluation or detox program (given the prevalence of chemical addiction in our communities). Indeed, the historical and social interrelationships of proselytizing religions and crippling chemical dependency are real. When both are combined with the ongoing intergenerational trauma associated with Indian boarding schools, there is reason to think that even a relative telling their family of a revelatory experience might find themselves being driven to the nearest mental health clinic. Considering how nations might react to such situations is crucial.

Unless serious efforts are made to address the everyday economic, health, housing, social, and cultural/spiritual dysfunctions found in many of our nations, one wonders if our nations are prepared to respond to the reception of new sacred lands as a result of revelatory

experiences. Again, those of you already attempting to address such tribal and community-threatening issues should take some solace in the fact that you are trying. And it is important to understand that there are places in North America where, looking in from the outside all one sees are the dysfunctions, but where, in fact, ancient Indigenous ceremonial traditions are strong and tribal virtues are again emerging and flowing, as Deloria suggested, "from the ongoing life of the community and . . . virtually indistinguishable from the tribal or communal customs." Also, lest anyone read the above as just another litany of the problems the poor Indians face, we must acknowledge that, sadly, the same list applies to many, not just the First Peoples, in the so-called land of the free and the home of the brave: the United States of America.

Discussions need to occur regarding customary tribal protocol or creation of new protocol for the reception of new sacred lands through revelation. Among whom, where, how, and to what end these discussions should occur are up to each tribe. Such discussions need not be public, but operating without any planning or consideration of rare events such as the one we have been discussing is a mistake. If one takes Deloria's analysis of sacred lands seriously—and I do, especially the fourth kind of sacred land—I suggest that if your nation has not thought deeply about what it means to *be ready to receive new revelations and at new locations*, then it is time to do so.

The list of considerations presented here are merely illustrative of the kinds of issues tribes might face. And we should expect issues to vary across tribal nations. But what about a more fundamental question we might consider in this age of the Anthropocene—the Age of Humankind? The planet, our Mother, has literally been blanketed in the past two hundred years with a physically heavy technosphere—roads, buildings, machinery, and the products of the industrial age—only to find herself now covered with the invisible satellite-driven electronic information and communication technology of the world-wide web. Therefore, a possibly existential question emerges: Do humans in this technology-blanketed planet still have the ability to receive the revelations certain sacred lands hold for us, especially if our "waking" hours are spent in virtual space—here, there, everywhere, and nowhere.

How Many Among Us Are Ready

In the age of alternative facts, "dog whistle" politics, viral tweets, pop culture influencers, celebrity cults of personality, propaganda, and outright lying, we have ushered in health concerns that our grandparents never could have imagined. Consequently, the health concerns raised here are not in the domain of aerobic exercise, vaccinations, diet, and physical fitness. Instead, the focus is on our mental and spiritual health

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in relationship to the land, in relationship to place. Deloria suggested that for American Indians the linkage between sacred lands and revelation was fundamental. It is impossible to imagine one existing without the other. When he formulated his onto-epistemological *3P* axiom of American Indian metaphysics, he clearly captured the relational character of reality. Dare I call it the sacred and the profane: what John Mohawk called the complex Web of Life?[17]

In this context—the essential relationship of the land to Indigenous spiritual or religious experiences—we must again ask, what happens to a communal (that is, tribal) reality when people in our places increasingly spend time looking at and listening to the flat-screen realities of their so-called smart devices? What happens when the primary involvement or engagement of our people is with flat-screen experiences that are literally here, there, everywhere, and nowhere—when the satellite-enabled digital technosphere increasingly eclipses the biosphere as the source of our experiences—when we no longer directly experience the living landscapes of the places that gave us our birth and tribal identities?

Many of our peoples have experienced US government removal and relocation policies and are now spending their lives experiencing the flat-screen images of reality or, more often than not, unrealities that are produced to sell something: ideas, ideologies, conspiracies, dreams, things advertising agencies tell us we need, and of course, objects—human-made things—that tell us we have *arrived* in the conspicuous-consumption wet dream of American success. Of course, this flat-screen reality is just that: flat and mobile, here, there, everywhere, and nowhere, and that is the problem.

Deloria put tremendous stock in the power of places. The challenge we have today is, Are people who are all so intently focused on their flat screens and experiencing virtual spaces that are here, there, everywhere, and nowhere still capable of the deep relationships to the land their ancestors possessed? We even have families together but alone on their flat-screen devices—everyone looking at something different, sharing their flat-screen experiences not with their family but with an untold number of strangers.

> What happens when people are now all *alone together*?
> When their community or communities are Facebook friends?
> When people share an internet space, a web address of many places (lands) scattered across the globe?

These technology-enabled gatherings, literally ungrounded, take on an ephemeral, abstract, digital-space-defined character and subject-matter-defined identity, but they hardly have a personality in

the sense that Deloria articulated the concept. Can we merely substitute "space" for "place" in Deloria's metaphysics of power and place equal personality? I think not.

Personality, for Deloria, was the nexus of peoples and places, a particular place on the planet where the power of the land (including the air and water), plants, and animals created a community in a fundamentally and literally grounded sense. In *God Is Red* Deloria repeatedly emphasized that events, when perceived through the lens of American Indian worldviews, are best understood as about the land, a place where events happened, rather than about when those events happened.

Deloria contended that even the creation stories of Indigenous Peoples are about places where creation happened, with little regard to a precise understanding of when they occurred. Deloria states, "Indian tribal religions could be said to consider creation as an ecosystem present in a definable place. In this distinction we have again the fundamental problem of whether we consider the reality of our experience as capable of being described in terms of space or time—as 'what happened here' or 'what happened then.'"[18]

It is not an exaggeration to say that Deloria's views, when applied to issues of tribal health or community wellness, focus on the manner in which a people relates to their land, Therefore, unburdened by making all past events and future events fit into a temporal timeline as embodied in Christianity's Genesis account of the beginning and the Book of Revelation's account of the End of Days, tribal religions "confront and interact with a particular land along with its life-forms. The task or role of the tribal religions is to relate the community of people to each and every facet of creation as they have experienced it."[19]

I believe Deloria understood the occurrence of revelations and their role in American Indian religions as being bound up in the complex relations that embody the Indian metaphysical 3P axiom. If so, one wonders whether Indigenous Peoples of the United States, entangled in the flat-screen spaces of the world wide web, still have the deep, spatial connection to a place required to receive revelations as our ancestors once did. We live entangled in *virtual* room-full-of-mirrors spaces where all we see is ourselves in the technology we made. It is nearly impossible to imagine www-dot virtual spaces as providing anything more than abstract anthropocentric space for sharing information about what "we think we know" and what some think we should know.[20]

In such virtual spaces the land—an "ecosystem present in a definable place" with animal, bird, or reptile participation—is clearly absent from a creation event. Therefore, while a www-dot space might be a site for demonstrating feats of human intelligence and, dare I say, discovery in a personal reflective sense, it is unlikely to be a portal for religious revelation since there is no "there," no real place, there.

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The question I believe we must ask is, Do we have healthy and well communities within our nations? Is there a *living* shared worldview where tribal values are embodied as virtues lived and demonstrated in our human relationships, our relationships with the natural world, and our respect for the sacred? According to Deloria, a tribe's relationship to the particular place they consider their homeland is the touchstone of tribal identity. Consequently, it is in the complex, manifold relationships found in the land—and for coastal and island peoples also the water—where their identity as a unique People, culture, and history emerges. And increasing numbers of people across our Mother Earth recognize our lands and waters—the places we call homelands—as sites for the assessment of community health.

We must think deeply about the current status of our relations/relationships in these homelands or home places. Following Deloria's thinking, a good approach might be consideration of what it would entail to put ourselves in *right relations* with the land where we live today—especially if that land is a new place in a new location. There is much to consider here: Are the places where Deloria tells us we must be prepared to receive revelations located within our ancient treaty-sacrificed, unceded, and expropriated (that is, stolen) homelands, or are these places outside our ancient homelands, locations where our tribal members (individuals and families) were moved by federal urban relocation and jobs programs or where tribal members chose to move for economic opportunities? The need to consider the interrelationship of Land Back activities and sacred lands is obvious, and despite the various configurations of colonialism globally, the *common ground* we share is our profound relationship to our lands. For this reason alone, the work we undertake within our nations to remind the world that within the vast majority of Indigenous or autochthonous Peoples' worldviews land is most fundamentally understood not as a resource or real estate but as a relative and the source of our tribal identities.

FINAL THOUGHTS

I believe Indigenous voices will be the most important voices of the twenty-first century, if we are to regain a *right relationship* with our Mother, the earth. But what is a *right relationship*? I answer based on what I have observed among young Indigenous leaders and many elders—not only old people but people with a deep mindfulness of their tribal traditions and the places they call home. Putting oneself in a right relationship most fundamentally means assuming a position of humility about power and knowing, and therefore, embodying a mindfulness regarding our activities and behavior: humility expressed in a decidedly non-anthropocentric worldview. In fact, my experience with

elders suggests that the notion that the world revolves around humans is anathema to most of our North American Indigenous worldviews, and this pervasive, even ubiquitous feature of modern thinking may be the most dangerous misstep humankind needs to step back from.

We may indeed look at the world through a human lens, but knowing this and understanding that seeing and sensing the world we live in involves much more than mere physical mechanics is crucial. The sense of sight is one part of human life that illustrates the power of the environment and life around us. We often experience this when we realize two individuals can look at the same image and see very different things. The different-than-human persons with whom we share the world also sense the world in ways we cannot. We may seek a correction to our anthropocentric sensing of the world with their assistance through experiencing ceremony, dreams, visions, and a mindful attentiveness to the world we share. Vine Deloria Jr. spoke of and wrote a book about *The World We Used to Live In*, with that title.[21]

Read it carefully, front to back; you will see Deloria ultimately suggests that world still exists. The fact that modern, civilized humankind cannot see it is a statement about what a great many of us have lost and what only a few still see, experience, and understand. With modern technology, humankind has certainly tried to shape the world to fit us, in a one-size-fits-all culture, but the good news is we have not changed it so much that the earth's wisdom and power have disappeared. For those willing to step outside themselves, outside the room-full-of-mirrors environments increasing numbers of humans inhabit (or are "occupied by") and leave their egos and ambitions behind, the sacred powers of Mother Earth remain ready to bestow new revelations in new places to those mindful of her and all her gifts.

Are our nations ready to receive new sacred lands through revelation? Some likely are, many may not be. In either case, if we take sacred lands seriously, it is time to prepare. How we will do this is up to each nation. If sovereignty means anything, it means a people's right to express their unalienable responsibilities to their land and the sacred powers experienced there in whatever way they see fit.

Can humans still receive the revelations the land holds for us? Yes, I think so, if we refuse to let the technosphere *occupy us*. As many of our youth immerse themselves in the new satellite-driven digital technologies and virtual imaging and realities, it remains to be seen if or how these technological landscapes might hold a sacred power for gifting revelations. My own concern is that these virtual landscapes are completely human-created, -imagined, and -reimagined. The landscapes Deloria speaks of are not, and the revelations received there owe much to the power of the physical and spiritual places we experience and which we, humankind, had nothing to do with. There are many questions and

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issues to be explored as some of us wrestle with the technosphere. Let us hope we can continue to think deeply about these issues.

In this fifty-first-anniversary year of the publication of Deloria's *God Is Red*, his closing words remain compelling: "Who will find peace with the lands? The future of humankind lies waiting for those who will come to understand their lives and take up their responsibilities to all living things. Who will listen to the trees, the animals and birds, the voices of the places of the land? As the long-forgotten peoples of the respective continents rise and begin to reclaim their ancient heritage, they will discover the meaning of the lands of their ancestors" (296). And, I believe, with this discovery will come a much-needed readiness to receive revelations of new sacred lands in the world we still live in.

AUTHOR BIOGRAPHY

Daniel R. Wildcat is a Yuchi member of the Muscogee Nation of Oklahoma. Wildcat is a longtime professor and researcher at Haskell Indian Nations University. Dr. Wildcat is currently the principal investigator at the Rising Voices, Changing Coasts Research Hub at Haskell. His books include *Power and Place: Indian Education In America*, with Vine Deloria Jr.; *Destroying Dogma: Vine Deloria's Legacy on Intellectual America*, with Steve Pavlik; *Red Alert: Saving the Planet with Indigenous Knowledge*; and most recently, *On Indigenuity: Learning the Lessons of Mother Earth*.

NOTES

1 Vine Deloria Jr., "Sacred Lands and Religious Freedom," *NARF Legal Review 16*, no. 2 (1991): 5.

2 Deloria, "Sacred Lands and Religious Freedom," 3.

3 Vine Deloria Jr., *God Is Red*, 3rd ed. (Golden, CO: Fulcrum 2003), chap. 4.

4 Deloria, *God Is Red*, 61.

5 Deloria, "Sacred Lands and Religious Freedom," 4.

6 Vine Deloria Jr. and Daniel Wildcat, *Power and Place: Indian Education in America* (Golden, CO: Fulcrum, 2001), 21–28.

7 Deloria, *God Is Red*, 277.

8 Vine Deloria Jr., For This Land, ed. James Treat (New York: Routledge, 1999). 254.

9 Deloria and Wildcat, *Power and Place*, 21–28.

10 Deloria and Wildcat, *Power and Place*, 21–22; quotation on p. 281.

11 Vine Deloria Jr., *The Metaphysics of Modern Existence* (New York: Harper & Row, 1979), 160.

12 Deloria, *Metaphysics*, 160.

13 Deloria, *Metaphysics*, 160, 161.

14 Deloria, *Metaphysics*, 161.

15 See Deloria and Wildcat, "Power and Place Equal Personality," chap. 3 in *Power and Place*.

16 Deloria, *God Is Red*, 67.

17 John Mohawk, "The Right of Animal Nations to Survive," *Daybreak Magazine*, Summer 1988.

18 Deloria, *God Is Red*, 77.

19 Deloria, God Is Red, 87.

20 See Alan Watts, introduction to *Nature, Man and Woman* (New York: Vintage Books, 1970), 2.

21 Vine Deloria Jr., *The World We Used to Live In: Remembering the Powers of the Medicine Men* (Golden, CO: Fulcrum, 2006).